PROJECTS IN LIMBO

Over a dozen initiatives launched by the SP government from 2012 to 2017 lie incomplete. Here are some of them



GOMTI RIVER FRONT, LUCKNOW: In **2014-15**, Rs 656 crore was allocated, which **escalated to Rs 1,513 crore.** By March 2017, despite 95 per cent of the amount being spent, only **60 per cent of the work** was completed. A CBI probe is blamed for the tardy progress

SUPERSPECIALITY HOSPITAL, SAIFAI: The state's largest superspeciality hospital with 500 beds was **planned in 2014** for Rs 333 crore, which later **escalated to Rs 537 crore.** In March, CM Yogi inaugurated it, but due to unfinished work and pending machine installations, services haven't started



GUEST HOUSE, SAIFAI: Construction began in **2015** for the 100-room project at **Rs 42 crore.** In 2017, **90 per cent** of the work was complete but is now stalled

CRICKET STADIUM, SAIFAI: Construction was **completed in 2018** at a cost of **Rs 200 crore.** With a capacity of 45,000 spectators, it boasts India's largest scoreboard, but needs Rs 50 crore to be operational

MOTHER AND CHILD HOSPITAL, SAIFAI: Foundation of the 300-bed hospital was laid in **2016. Only 60 per cent of the work is complete.** Rs 177 crore was sanctioned, but **only Rs 30 crore was given** in the past five years

ALL-WEATHER SWIMMING POOL, SAIFAI: Completed in **October 2016** at a cost of **Rs 207 crore.** The pool, with a seating capacity for 4,000 spectators, is now under the sports department, but remains shut due to a lack of electricity connection and accommodation facilities for players

MUGHAL MUSEUM, AGRA: The state-of-the-art project near the Taj Mahal **began in 2015.** Work stopped at the end of 2016, leading to a **cost escalation from Rs 140 crore to Rs 180 crore.** The BJP government renamed it after Shivaji, but that has not eased funds crunch

PERFUME PARK, KANNAUJ: The project, **launched in April 2016** and built on 100 acres at a cost of around **Rs 60 crore**, was inaugurated by CM Yogi on February 3, but key arrangements remain incomplete

ROADSIDE CAFÉ STREET, AGRA: Planned in September 2013 to provide world-class facilities to tourists. For this, 7,120 sq. metres of land were allotted, and Rs 12 crore of an estimated Rs 30 crore was released. The project is **stuck in a land dispute**

the LDA has no provision for this."

If JPNIC is the centrepiece of the unfinished projects of the SP era, several other initiatives in Lucknow, Kannauj, Agra and Saifai are still hanging in the balance (see *Projects in Limbo*). The Gomti River Front has also fallen victim allegedly to partisan politics, compounded by corruption charges. It has been six and a half years since a CBI investigation began, yet there seems to be no progress toward a conclusion.

Former member of the UP Planning Commission and Lucknow University professor, Sudhir Panwar, says, "Like many other development projects, the Gomti River Front has become a victim of politics. If corruption is involved, a deadline should be set for completing the investigation. The delay suggests that the government is intentionally stalling to keep the issue alive."

Mulayam Singh Yadav's birthplace Saifai, once the centre for several initiatives under the SP regime, has now become a graveyard of unfinished projects

Mulayam's native village Saifai in Etawah district, once attracting the lion's share of the development initiatives during the SP regime, has now become a graveyard of unfinished projects. Saifai resident and Azamgarh MP Dharmendra Yadav says, "By halting development projects funded with public money, the government has shown its true intentions." Reacting to this, former BJP MP from Etawah, Ram Shankar Katheria, says, "Many projects, such as the international cricket stadium and all-weather swimming pool in Saifai, lacked justification. These are examples of the SP government's waste of public funds." Before this year's Lok Sabha election, Adityanath inaugurated the Superspeciality Hospital in Saifai, but it is expected to be operational in two months.

Although the Chief Minister's Office sought a status report from officials on the development projects initiated by the SP government in January this year, no concrete action has been taken yet. And so the projects continue to lie in disrepair. ■